

A SAMPLE LESSON

The Interior

BOOK THREE · GRADES 6-8

Unit 1 · Lesson 1 — “The Mask vs. The Mirror”

THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · CURRICULUM

School of Life Foundation

The Mask vs. The Mirror

35–40 min • September Week 1

OBJECTIVE

Students distinguish between the persona they project socially (Mask) and their authentic self (Mirror), and identify at least two gaps using the Identity Audit.

CASEL FOCUS

Self-Awareness — accurate self-perception and identity formation.

SCENARIO CARDS

1A (Amara — New School, New Mask) • 1B (Jordan — The Class Clown)

SAFETY CHECK • BEFORE CLASS

Confirm crisis resource numbers are posted visibly — **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline • Crisis Text Line: text HOME to 741741**. Know your counselor's name and same-day contact method. This lesson is not high-disclosure-risk — but the Identity Audit occasionally surfaces something significant for students carrying heavy self-perception burdens.

ANCHOR CHART • MASK VS. MIRROR (TWO-COLUMN DISPLAY)

The Mask — what I show, what I perform, what I hide, what I emphasise. **The Mirror** — what is actually there when the performance stops: my real opinions, my actual struggles, what I value. *Grades 7–8 add: "The gap between these two is where the cost lives."*

OPENING • 3–4 MINUTES

"Think about the last time you walked into a social situation and consciously thought about how you were coming across. What were you managing? What were you hiding?" Pause 10 seconds. Students write in journals for 60 seconds before any discussion.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION • STEPS 1–4

1

Introduce the Mask

5 MIN

"Everyone wears a Mask — a social performance. The Mask is not always dishonest. Often it is sensible. The problem is when the Mask becomes so habitual that we lose contact with what is underneath." Point to the Mask column. Take 2–3 answers.

2

Introduce the Mirror

5 MIN

"The Mirror is what is actually there when the performance stops. The Mirror is not more virtuous than the Mask. It is just more real." Point to the Mirror column. Take 2–3 answers.

IN-LESSON SCAN

Observe: students who go very still during the Mirror introduction, or look away from the chart. **May signal:** high identity fusion with a curated self, or fear of what they would find underneath. **Action:** note privately; do not address publicly; monitor through Unit 2.

3

Identity Audit — Private

10 MIN

“Left column: who I am when I am performing. Right column: who I am when I am not performing — what I actually think, feel, value, and struggle with. Work in complete silence. This is private.” Set a visible 10-minute timer. Circulate — do not read over shoulders. The worksheet is never collected, never shared unless the student chooses.

IN-LESSON SCAN

Observe: a student who stares at the blank worksheet for more than 2 minutes, or writes a single word and stops.

Action: move quietly toward them after 2–3 minutes; say low, “You can label the columns with one word each if that helps.” Do not linger. Note for the Unit 2 watch list.

4

Discussion — The Gap

8 MIN

“Without revealing the contents of your columns — where is the gap between your two sides biggest? What does maintaining that gap cost you — in energy, in authenticity, in connection?” Then: “What would it take to reduce the gap by even 10%?” Let this sit without requiring answers aloud.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: scaffold the Identity Audit with concrete examples first — sports tryouts, lunch-table choices, what you post vs. what you feel. *Grades 7–8:* introduce “identity foreclosure” — committing to a persona so early you stop questioning it: “When did you decide who you were going to be, and was that decision really yours?”

EXIT TICKET · JOURNAL (NEVER COLLECTED, NEVER GRADED)

“The version of me that almost no one sees is _____. Why does that version stay hidden?”

FAMILY CONNECTION · A NOTE HOME

Today we began our identity unit by examining the gap between the persona students perform socially and who they actually are. You can open this at home by modelling vulnerability — share a moment when you felt like you were “performing” rather than being real.

THIS LESSON INCLUDES

Anchor Chart

Identity Audit (WS1)

Scenario Cards 1A / 1B

Regulation & Repair Strand

END OF THE SAMPLE LESSON

The gap between the two is where the cost lives.

The Interior · Book Three of The Architecture of Grace · Grades 6–8